

When the enemy was spotted, piles of sticks and wood were set alight on top of these watch towers. The "wolf smoke" they gave off could be seen for miles. It was called wolf smoke because wolves were seen as a sign of danger in China.

The hut on the guard tower roof provided cover from bad weather and extra storage space for food and weapons.

A vast construction

The Wall that is visible today was mainly built during the Ming Dynasty (1368-1644), with most work happening in the mid-1500s. Parts of the Wall have been carefully restored, such as this section at Mutianyu.



The "Wild Wall"

Some sections of the Wall, like Jiankou, close to Mutianyu, are in a very poor state of repair. Today these crumbling areas are called the "Wild Wall."

Secret ingredient

Until very recently, scientists wondered why the mortar holding the bricks of the Wall had lasted so long and remained so strong. Tests have now shown that the mortar cement of limestone and sand had a secret ingredient that made it super-strong: ground-up sticky rice. Also called glutinous rice, it actually gets harder the older it gets.

